a FlexLifeFi K–12 program

GRADE 7 · PARENT GUIDE

What to Watch For at Home

One good question per quarter — no quizzing, no pressure.

Year theme: Know Your Customer

CONTENTS

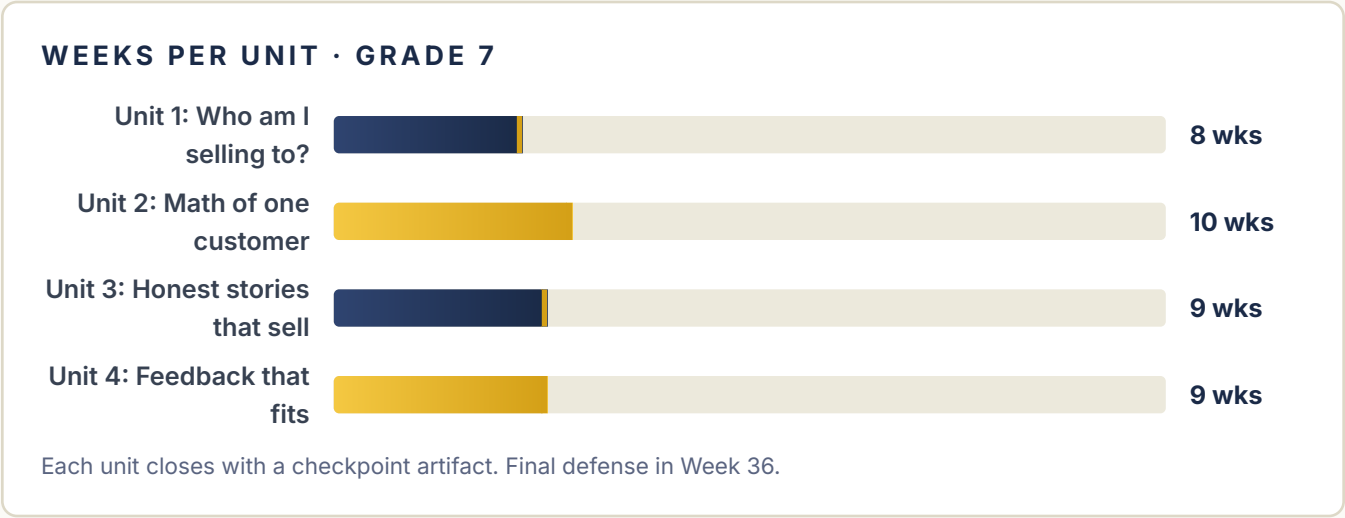
What's Inside

01 What this year is
02 What your student is bringing home
03 What you don't need to do
04 What you can do (if you want)
05 Things to watch for
06 Conversation starters (if you want)
07 Privacy and sensitivity
08 A note about success this year
09 Questions?
10 Senior expert upgrade pack — Two more ad-spotting prompts
11 ROUND 2 PATCH — Three 30-Second Conversation Starters per Quarter (Grade 7)
12 ROUND 2 PATCH — What Cash Never Says (Parent Reference)

YEAR-AT-A-GLANCE

Four Units. Thirty-Six Weeks. One Capstone.

The year is built as four units, each ending with a public-facing artifact that feeds the rolling Capstone. The bars show how the weeks are spent — roughly equal, with a slight lean toward the math-heavy unit because per-customer math is the load-bearing skill.



36 WEEKS

4 UNITS

10 LESSONS

8 CASH VIDEOS

GRADE 7 · PARENT GUIDE

What to Watch For at Home

Customers are evidence, not assumptions.

A short, practical guide for the adult who lives with a Grade 7 Cash to Company student.

What this year is

"Revenue is loud. Contribution margin is true."

— CASH

This year, your student is learning to think like an entrepreneur — not by making money, but by paying attention. The big move of the year is **knowing your customer**: figuring out, with evidence, who a product is actually for and what they actually need.

Across the year, your student designs a small "Capstone venture" — a hypothetical (or sometimes real) business idea they sharpen through customer interviews, basic per-customer math, marketing messaging, and feedback collection. By June, they'll deliver a 5-minute defense of what they learned about a customer, a price, a message, and a change they made.

Most students do not start a real business this year. The point is not the business. The point is the muscles: listening, doing the math, telling the truth, listening some more.

What your student is bringing home

You'll see:

- A **Capstone Journal** — the messy notebook where they sketch, plan, and reflect.
- A **Student Activity Book** — the structured worksheets with persona pages, pricing math, A/B test results, and reflection prompts.
- Occasional **Cash videos** to watch (2–3 minutes each) — short animated explainers from the program's mascot, Cash.
- An **interview script** — your student will probably do customer interviews. If they want to interview you, lovely. You can also decline; they have other options.

They'll likely talk about their "persona," "contribution margin," "A/B test," and "signal vs. noise." If those terms feel new, that's fine — you don't need to know them. Your student will explain.

What you don't need to do

- **You don't need to know any of this.** A parent with no business background can fully support this curriculum.
- **You don't need to fund anything.** Capstones are educational. If your student wants to launch a real venture, that's a family decision and outside the curriculum's expectations.
- **You don't need to share your finances.** Curriculum-wide policy: no student is asked to share family financial details. If your student asks you a money question that feels invasive, redirect them — there's no homework that requires it.

What you can do (if you want)

> *"Listening is not a moment. It's a system."*
>
> — CASH

These are optional and low-effort. None of them are required.

1. Ask one good question a week

Try one of these on a car ride or over dinner:

- **September–October:** "What did you learn about your customer this week that surprised you?"
- **November–January:** "What does each customer 'cost' your business? What's left over?"
- **February–April:** "What's the difference between persuading and tricking someone? Where would you draw the line?"
- **May–June:** "What feedback was hardest to hear? What did you do about it?"

You don't need to know the right answer. You're modeling curiosity, not expertise.

2. Be a customer (if asked)

Your student may ask to interview you. Treat it like a real interview — give them honest answers, including the boring parts. The most useful thing you can do is not be a cheerleader. Honest customer evidence beats supportive customer evidence every time.

If interviewing you doesn't feel right, it's fine to say so. There are alternatives — your student can interview teachers, neighbors, or other students.

3. Notice ads with them

When you see an ad that feels manipulative — fake countdown timer, "doctors hate this trick," a vague "everyone is buying" — ask your student what they think. They've been trained on a 4-point check (clear claim, honest price, real reviews, easy returns). Hearing them apply it is a window into how they think.

4. Share a "small business" story

If you've ever started something small — a side service, a club, a fundraiser, even a household project — your story is gold. Your student is learning that real ventures involve showing up, being wrong, and adjusting. The most useful thing you can share is what you got wrong and what you did about it.

If you haven't started anything like that, you can ask a friend, neighbor, grandparent, or colleague who has. The "founder origin story" is more interesting than the "founder success story."

Things to watch for

A "great idea" that needs you to spend money

Your student gets excited about a venture and wants you to fund supplies. Two responses both work:

- **"What did your math say it would cost? What's the contribution margin?"** (Pulls them into the work.)
- **"This sounds like a real-life version, not a class version. We can talk about whether to do that."** (Separates the curriculum from the family decision.)

Customer "interviews" that are gossip

A student says "I learned that Maya hates the cafeteria food." Coach: "That's a quote, but is it customer evidence? Did she say what she'd want instead, and would she pay for it?" Anonymize what they bring home — the curriculum norm is to use only initials in transcripts.

Something that doesn't sit right ethically

If your student's venture leans toward exclusion, manipulation, body-image messaging, or anything else that pings you, mention it to the teacher. The curriculum has built-in pivot windows three times during the year for exactly this. Teachers welcome family flags.

Real money requests

If your student asks for real money (a $40 supply order, a $25 ad spend), this is a family conversation, not a curriculum requirement. The Capstone can be done entirely on paper. If you're considering a real-money launch, the program's high-school years are the better time for it.

Conversation starters (if you want)

- "Tell me one quote a customer actually said this week."
- "If you priced your thing $1 higher, would more people not buy?"
- "What's a fixed cost in your business?"
- "Was anything in your survey hard to read?"
- "If your customer changed her mind tomorrow, what would you change first?"

Privacy and sensitivity

"A little less wrong, every week."

— CASH

The curriculum:

- Uses **fictional names** for personas, not classmates' real names.
- Asks students to use **initials only** in interview transcripts.
- Avoids **family financial details** entirely. No homework asks how much your family spends on anything.
- Uses **neutral examples** that don't assume specific home situations.

If something feels off, contact the teacher. The teacher can adjust assignments, swap ventures, or modify pacing for any reason — including a flag from a caregiver.

A note about success this year

A "successful" Grade 7 Cash to Company student does not necessarily start a business, make money, or impress a panel. A successful student:

- Talked to at least three real customers.
- Computed a contribution margin and revised it.
- Wrote a marketing message they could defend.

- Made at least one change because of feedback.
- Wrote, at the end of the year, "the biggest thing I got wrong on Day 1 was..."

If you see those four things on the kitchen table over the year, the program worked.

Questions?

Your student's teacher is the first stop for any question about the curriculum. They can also send home longer-form materials (the full Curriculum Book, the Lesson Plans) if you'd like a deeper look.

Thank you for being part of this. The biggest predictor of whether a financial-thinking habit sticks is whether it's also alive at home — even at the level of one curious question a week.

— The Cash to Company team

Senior expert upgrade pack — Two more ad-spotting prompts

"Being wrong on Day 1 is the deal."

— CASH

The original Parent Guide gives one excellent ad-spotting question. Two more for variety.

The "doctors recommend" prompt

You: "This ad says doctors recommend it. Which doctors?" Child: (may not know) You: "What would your school project's 4-point check say?"

(They've been trained on: clear claim, honest price, real reviews, easy returns.)

The "limited time only" prompt

You: "This says 'today only.' If we come back tomorrow, will it be gone?" Child: (answers; usually says no) You: "What's that called when an ad says 'only today' but the deal is always there?"

(They've been trained: scarcity that's invented to pressure.)

You don't need to know what the ad is doing. The kid does. Your job is to ask.

ROUND 2 PATCH — Three 30-Second Conversation Starters per Quarter (Grade 7)

Quarter 1 (Customer Persona) 1. At dinner: "Whos your customer? Tell me their name, age, daily routine, and frustration." — Follow-up: "How do you know?" 2. Drive-time: "Whats a business youve seen that really knew its customer? How could you tell?" — Follow-up: "What signs in their store/site?" 3. Watching a commercial: "Whos the target customer here? How can you tell?" — Follow-up: "Whod be left out?"

Quarter 2 (Per-Customer Revenue + Contribution Margin) 1. At a coffee shop: "Each customer pays $5. Each cup costs them $1 in materials. Whats their contribution margin per customer?" — Sample: "$4." — Follow-up: "What if rent is $1000/month — how many customers do they need?" 2. Drive-time: "If a babysitter earns $40 a night and spends $5 on snacks for the kids, whats their contribution per gig?" — Sample: "$35." — Follow-up: "Whats their per-customer revenue?" 3. In the kitchen: "These cookies cost $0.30 each to make. We sold for $1. Per-customer revenue $1, contribution $0.70. How many to make $50 profit?" — Sample: "About 72."

Quarter 3 (Day-1 vs. Day-30 + Customer Feedback) 1. After they file a Day-1 letter: "Whats your Day 1 assumption? Lets remember it for 30 days." — Follow-up: "Whats one thing youll watch for?" 2. Drive-time: "Whats one assumption you had at the start of school that turned out wrong?" — Follow-up: "How did you find out?" 3. Watching a TV show: "What feedback would the customer give if asked one question?" — Follow-up: "What question?"

Quarter 4 (4-Point Fair-to-Customer Check)

When you see a kid-aimed product page (Amazon, app store, etc.), ask:

1. Clear claim? "Does the product page say specifically what the product does?"
2. Honest price? "Is the price clear, or are there hidden fees?"
3. Real reviews? "Do the reviews look like real customers, or are they suspicious?"
4. Easy returns? "If the customer doesnt like it, can they easily get money back?"

If 3 out of 4 fail, the product page isnt fair to the customer. Pass on it.

Sensitivity: None of these require the family to share home finances. They work for any family.

ROUND 2 PATCH — What Cash Never Says (Parent Reference)

Cash will never say: "Amazing!" / "Everyone can be rich" / "Easy money" / "Passive income" / "Just believe in yourself" (as substitute for evidence) / anything implying money problems are a personal failing.

Cash always asks: "Which people, and how do you know?" / "Whats the evidence?"

Why this matters at home. Your child will encounter financial-literacy content from many sources, some hustle-bro coded. The contrast is the point. Cash is on your familys side: clear-eyed, honest, never selling.

One question this year: "Did Cash ask you a question this week? What was it?"

ABOUT THE HOST

Cash, in five words

curious · warm · honest · patient · specific

"I'm Cash. I don't promise wealth. I don't promise success. I promise that the moves — interview, math, message, listen — will make you a clearer thinker about money no matter what you end up doing."

— CASH

What Cash does

- **Asks questions that point to evidence.** Cash never tells; Cash asks what your evidence says.
- **Names rules sparingly.** "An assumption is something you think is true without checking. Evidence is something you observed, heard, or counted."
- **Tells short, made-up-but-realistic stories.** 30–60 seconds, shows don't tell.
- **Celebrates the move, not the win.** Revision, honesty, and evidence — not revenue.
- **Hedges deliberately.** probably, often, sometimes — never absolutes about complex topics.

What Cash never does

- Flatter ("amazing!", "great job!"), promise wealth, moralize about money.
- Reference real brands or living celebrities as endorsements.
- Surface family financial details. (Hypothetical scenarios only.)
- Pretend the world is fair. Cash is honest about systemic factors without becoming a politics class.

> *When in doubt, work one of these into the script: Which people, and how do you know? · Being wrong on Day 1 is the deal. · Revenue is loud. Contribution margin is true. · A little less wrong, every week.*

STRAND OUTCOMES

Eight Strands. One Year. Verifiable Outcomes.

Cash to Company runs the same eight strands K-12. Each year deepens the demonstration. The Grade 7 version of each strand is below.

Code	Strand	Grade 7 demonstrated outcome
BAVC	Business Awareness and Value Creation	Identify a business problem, propose a value-creation hypothesis, and revise it with customer evidence.
PSIG	Problem Solving and Idea Generation	Generate, screen, and refine ideas; document why one was chosen and the others were not.
MFL	Money and Financial Literacy	Compute revenue, variable cost, contribution margin, and breakeven for a real product or service.
CBM	Customers, Branding, Marketing	Build a persona from interview evidence; design honest messaging; A/B test two claims.
OSO	Operations, Systems, Organization	Design a simple weekly operating cadence with named roles, handoffs, and a feedback loop.
LTO	Leadership, Teamwork, Ownership	Run and document a team meeting; resolve one disagreement using shared evidence.
ESL	Ethics, Safety, Legal Awareness	Identify the line between persuasion and manipulation; flag one borderline claim and rewrite it honestly.
LRCI	Launch Readiness and Continuous Improvement	Pilot, measure, and document at least three iterations with rationale and what changed.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

Six Benchmarks This Year

Standards are cited at the benchmark level. Honest gaps are named when they exist.
The Capstone artifact addresses each one.

Benchmark	What students must demonstrate
Jump$tart 6 (Financial Decision Making) 8-2	Identify ways consumers may avoid making poor decisions; apply to entrepreneurs avoiding poor customer guesses.
CCSS-ELA W.7.4	Produce clear and coherent writing in which the development, organization, and style are appropriate to task.
CCSS-ELA SL.7.1	Engage effectively in a range of collaborative discussions.
CASEL Social Awareness	Recognize the perspectives of others; demonstrate empathy.
C3 D2.Eco.1.6-8	Explain how economic decisions affect well-being of individuals, businesses, society.
Jump$tart 1 (Spending & Saving) 8-2	Demonstrate ability to use number skills to manage money.

HOW TO READ THIS TABLE

Each lesson cites at least one of these benchmarks. Each Capstone checkpoint addresses two or more. The Teacher Guide includes a per-lesson standards crosswalk.

"Standards aren't a cage. They're a list of moves you're going to be glad you can make. Pick one. Practice it. Move on."

— CASH

CAPSTONE RUBRIC (4-POINT)

How We Score the Capstone

The Capstone artifact is scored on four traits, each on a 4-point scale. Honest, specific, decision-oriented work earns the high marks. Generic or assumption-laden work earns the low ones.

Trait	1 — Emerging	2 — Developing	3 — Proficient	4 — Advanced
Evidence quality	Mostly assumptions; few or no quotes.	2-3 interview quotes; partial evidence.	5+ direct quotes; varied sources; coded patterns.	Triangulated quotes plus behavioral observation; counter-evidence acknowledged.
Per-customer math	Confused costs; no contribution margin.	CM computed but with errors; one price scenario.	Correct CM and breakeven; clear pricing rationale.	CM under multiple price scenarios; LTV-lite reasoning.
Honest messaging	Vague or misleading claims.	Some specifics; some unsupported claims.	All claims supported; clean ethics check.	A/B-tested copy with rationale; resists clever-but-borderline phrasing.
Feedback system	One-time check; no documentation.	Ad-hoc feedback; partial revisions.	1-week feedback loop with 3 documented changes.	Sustained loop plus signal-vs-noise analysis plus revision log.

CALIBRATION NOTE

Score honestly. A "3" means the student met the standard the way an adult professional would. A "4" means they did something a working entrepreneur would be proud to show. Withhold "4" unless the work earns it.

SENSITIVITY AND FAMILY ENGAGEMENT

What We Don't Ask. What We Always Frame.

Money is a tool, not a virtue. Some students live in households with credit-card debt, low or no banking access, or active financial stress. The curriculum is built so that none of those students is asked to disclose, perform, or apologize for their family situation.

Rules of the room

- **Never ask about family money.** No questions about parents income, debts, accounts, or banking status.
- **Use neutral hypotheticals.** "For a sample family with a $4,000/month take-home" — not "your family."
- **Decouple wealth from worth.** Cash never says "everyone can be rich." Cash says "you will be a clearer thinker about money no matter what you end up doing."
- **Name systemic factors honestly.** Wage gaps, geography, and luck shape outcomes. The skill we build is the skill in the student hands.
- **Protect the venture.** A student Capstone is theirs. We don't require they share revenue or family contribution. The artifact is the work, not the bank account.

Family engagement

Parents get one well-framed question per quarter — never a quiz, never a money-disclosure prompt. The default frame is curiosity ("What did you notice about your customers this week?"), not interrogation ("How much did you make?").

"Money is a tool. The question is not whether your family has a lot of it. The question is what you do with the moves we are practicing — interview, math, message, listen — wherever your starting line happens to be."

— CASH

ACTIVITY INDEX

Ten Activities. One Notebook.

Every activity in this book is built to be done with a pencil, your own evidence, and the questions Cash keeps asking. Skip nothing. Date everything. Re-read in three months.

No.	Activity	What you will do
01	Day 1 Customer Assumption	One sentence, one card. Don't try to be right; try to be specific.
02	Open vs. Leading Questions	Rewrite five leading questions into open ones. Practice on a partner.
03	Coding Patterns from Transcripts	Highlight surprises, frustrations, wishes. Tally them. Find the pattern.
04	Persona Pack v1	Combine evidence into one specific person — name, behaviors, top frustration.
05	Variable Cost per Unit	From a real receipt, compute the cost per one of the thing you sell.
06	Contribution Margin Worksheet	Price minus variable cost. Decide if it covers your fixed costs.
07	Two-Message A/B Test	Two honest messages. Three-day test. Report the winner and why.
08	Persuasion vs. Manipulation Line	Sort 10 ad claims onto a line. Defend your placement.
09	1-Week Feedback Loop	Collect, code, and act on feedback. Document three changes.
10	Final Capstone Defense	Five slides. Five minutes. Show the moves you made.

NOTEBOOK SETUP

Get a single notebook for the whole year. Number every page. The first 5 pages are your Vocabulary Spine. The last 5 pages are your Day-1 Assumptions (you will come back to those). Everything in between is your work.

Notebook checklist

- **Title page** — your name, your venture working-title, today's date.
- **Vocabulary spine** — 5 pages reserved for definitions you will add as we go.
-

Customer notes — one section for interview transcripts. Use direct quotes, with initials and dates.

- **Math section** — receipts taped in, per-unit computations, contribution margin scratch work.
- **Messaging section** — drafts of two-claim A/B tests, with what won and why.
- **Feedback log** — one page per week of your feedback system, with the three changes you made.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked Example: Per-Customer Math at the Snack Stand

Devon sells protein cookies after school. He sells 30 cookies a week at $2.00 each. Revenue is $60. He spends $0.85 on each cookie (oats, peanut butter, packaging). His variable cost per cookie is $0.85.

Contribution margin per cookie = $2.00 - $0.85 = **$1.15**. His fixed cost (the table he rents from the school store) is $20/week. He needs **$20 / $1.15 = 18 cookies/week** just to cover the table. He's currently selling 30. He's clearing $14.50/week after fixed costs.

Devon's question to Cash: should he raise the price to $2.50? Cash answers with a question: "Which people, and how do you know? Run a 3-day test. Half the kids see $2.00. Half see $2.50. Tell me what they actually buy."

WHAT TO COPY

The move here is not the answer. It is the structure: specific number, specific person, specific decision. Use that pattern in your own venture this quarter.

> *"Most adults skip this. You won't. Pick one customer. Compute one number. Decide one thing." — Cash*

END-OF-QUARTER REFLECTION

Four Quarters. Same Five Questions.

At the end of every quarter you will answer the same five questions. The answers should look different over time. Reread the previous quarter before you write a new one.

1. **Which people did you talk to this quarter, and what did they actually say?**

   Specific quotes, initials, dates. Resist the urge to summarize.
2. **What did you change in your venture because of evidence?**

   Name the change. Name the evidence that caused it.
3. **What is one number you know better now than three months ago?**

   Variable cost per unit. Contribution margin. Anything quantitative.
4. **What is a claim you made that you would take back?**

   Be honest. The claim does not have to be public. The honesty is the move.
5. **What would Cash ask you about all of this?**

   "Which people, and how do you know?" is always available. Find your own version.

> *"Reflection is not a feeling check-in. It is a memory tool. The you in three months wants to know what the you today learned. Write it down so future-you can use it."*
>
> — CASH

One promise.

Cash to Company makes one promise: students who move through this program will be clearer thinkers about money and entrepreneurship — no matter what they end up doing for a living.

We do not promise wealth. We do not promise success. We promise clarity.

"Customers are evidence, not assumptions."

— CASH, GRADE 7